

The Open Movement and the Implications of its Opportunities in Education

In this article, we look at what role the various 'open movements' can play in academia, and how academia should nurture them for a win-win relationship.

Over the last few years, the concept of openness has been spreading its wings far and wide in many guises. Much of it started with the popularity of the FOSS (free and open source software) movement. Though dating back to Richard M. Stallman's days at MIT, it gathered popularity only on the arrival of the Linux kernel from Linus Torvalds in the early 90s. Since then, the movement has never looked back.

Almost every large corporation is involved in the movement in one way or another, with IBM, Sun, Intel, HP, etc, leading the way. The movement has got into the legislative bodies of many countries, creating pressure at the level of policies, guidelines, etc, to support and adopt FOSS wherever possible. Many countries have taken explicit steps to nurture a FOSS ecosystem, by training programs, certifications, resource centres, and so on.

Today, FOSS is a familiar term across

the world, spanning academia, industry, government, and SMEs. The FOSS activities have a number of dimensions, stretching well beyond the availability of software with source code. It has led to sibling movements in content, standards, hardware, systems, etc. Each of these has attained a fair degree of maturity today.

Academia has always related to FOSS's way of thought quite easily, thanks to the same underlying philosophy. However, there have been pressures from the proprietary software world, often derailing the curriculum in many cases, and disrupting the balance between conceptual foundations and commercial aspects. An example is the issue of a vendor-neutral syllabus in India, which has been in the air for a long time.

Here, we look at the role the various 'open movements'—a term to denote the set of movements consisting of free and open source software, open standards, open content, open